# The Mother

## By Richard Exley

## INTRODUCTION

*Mary the Mother of Jesus is undoubtedly the best known of all the eyewitnesses to His death and resurrection. No human being suffered more than she did. Watching the crucifixion of her Son was nearly more than she could bear. Yet even in His death she found hope. She took refuge in all that had been promised her that day so long ago when the angel told her that she had been chosen to be the virgin mother of the savior of the world. And her faith was rewarded for the son she watched die was raised from the dead on the third day! From the mind and soul of Mary, The Mother by Richard Exley.*

OPENING THE SHUTTERS I STARE, WITH UNSEEING EYES, at the city shrouded in darkness below me. Morning is still a long way off, but I cannot bear to lie in bed a moment more. All night I've tossed and turned, tormented by thoughts of my son and what's to become of him. In my mind, I've replayed Simeon's fateful prophecy again and again.

Against my better judgment, I have allowed my sister Salome, I the mother of James and John, to persuade me to join her family in Jerusalem for the Passover. Secretly I hoped to see Jesus, though if the rumors I have heard are true, it would not be wise for him to risk making an appearance. Still, I hoped I might have a few minutes with him.

By the time I arrived, late Wednesday afternoon of Passover week, the city was wild with rumors. Jesus was reported to be here, but no one knows where. Mter entering the city in triumph on Sunday, he cleansed the temple on Monday, throwing out the money changers and driving out those who were selling. On

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Tuesday he dared to return to the temple to teach the people. And again early Wednesday he spoke, but then he disappeared-with good reason, for the chief priests are determined to put him to death.
We heard nothing all day Thursday, which was yesterday. I hope and pray he has slipped away, but in my heart I know it is not to be. The sword of which Simeon spoke is already doing its deadly work. With great effort I force myself to think of more pleasant things. Like the night my first-born son came into the world.

Behind me I hear the soft rustle of cloth. Turning from the window I discover Salome has entered my room. Placing her candle on a ledge she makes her way to me. Taking both of my hands in hers she says, "I saw your light and thought you might like some company."

She is such a dear sister. Always available, but never prying. Giving her a wan smile I say, "I was just thinking of the night Jesus was born."

"Please tell me about it," she says, drawing me out with her kindness.
"It's a long story," I warn her.
She just smiles and says, "We have the rest of the night."
Taking a deep breath I begin. "It wasn't a difficult birth as births go. Still, I didn't have anyone to help me except Joseph, and you know how helpless men can be at times like that. It's not the primitive stable or the bitter cold that I remember, or even my fear. All of that was forgotten as soon as I heard Jesus cry.

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"There wasn't any water in the stable, so I used fresh straw to wipe him clean. Then I tore strips of cloth from a nearly new blanket and wrapped him in them. Joseph made a cradle of the manger, and we laid him there. I don't think I've ever been as happy as I was that night."

Salome gives my hand a squeeze and nods knowingly, having given birth to children of her own.

"Forty days later, after the time of our purification according to the law of Moses, we took Jesus to the temple to present him to the Lord. I wish we could have afforded a lamb, but all we could manage was two young pigeons. Still, I was so proud, especially when Simeon blessed him. He began to prophesy, and my blood ran cold. 'This child,' he said, 'is destined to cause the falling and rising of many in Israel.'

"Then came the words I've never been able to forget, Words that I've lived with all these years. Turning to me, he looked deep into my eyes and said, 'A sword will pierce your own soul too.'

"I asked Joseph what he thought Simeon meant, but he just shrugged it off. 'The irrational ramblings of a senile old man' Was his conclusion. I knew better, and it wasn't long until my fearful premonitions proved correct.

"Jesus was barely two years old when King Herod ordered all the boys his age and under in Bethlehem and the surrounding area to be put to death. "When I learned

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of this evil decree, I was sick with fear. The nights were the worst. Sleep would not come, and when it did., I was tormented with terrifying dreams in which baby Jesus was torn from my arms and killed. More than once I awoke. screaming, bathed in a cold sweat, the taste of fear bitter in my mouth.

"Joseph did What he could, but I would not be comforted, not as long as Jesus was in danger. Thankfully, God intervened. The angel of the Lord appeared to Joseph in a dream. 'Get up,' he said. 'Take the child and his mother and escape to Egypt.'
"Though we fled Bethlehem that very night, it was_____ before I felt safe, really safe. Even in Egypt, fear was a _____ every day.
"As you might guess, I became something of an overprotective mother. I wouldn't let Jesus out of my sight. I h____ over him, treasuring every smile, every slobbery kiss,
_____them in my heart against that terrible day when he would be taken from me.
"It was to be many years before my fears were fully _____. There were even times when I could almost forget that prophecy, so ordinary did life seem. Jesus was good "" hands and seemed at home in the carpentry shop. Still, it could not last, and as the years went by I sensed a g restlessness in him. With increasing frequency I caught him staring off in the distance with a faraway look in his eye

"One evening, just weeks before he turned thirty returning from the well, where I had gone to draw water, I saw him emerge from his shop. Turning toward the v wearily stretched his arms wide, casting the shadow of _____on the wall behind

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him. In that instant Simeon's sword my heart afresh. I knew that Jesus was going to die, and the way he would die. Don't ask me how. Perhaps

"I remember the day he left Nazareth as clearly as if it were yesterday. He got work started in the shop, and then he came to me. He didn't say anything. What was there to say? For a long time he held me, and no mother was ever more loved. Then he was gone, without a backward look.

"For awhile we didn't hear anything. Then news began to filter back. John, our cousin Elizabeth's son, the one people called the Baptist, had declared that Jesus was 'the Lamb of God, who takes away the sin of the world!'
"Sometime later a peddler brought news of Jesus' baptism. He witnessed it with his own eyes. According to his account he saw the Holy Spirit descend on Jesus in the form of a dove when Jesus emerged from the water. At the same time a voice from
heaven said: 'You are my Son, whom I love; with you I am well pleased. '

"For several weeks we didn't hear anything more. Later we learned that Jesus had fasted and prayed for forty days while doing battle with the tempter in the wilderness. Then he returned to Nazareth, and never was a mother more proud. When he stood up in the synagogue to read on the Sabbath, I thought my heart would burst with joy. He read so well. His voice was so rich, so resonant. 'The Spirit of the Lord is on me,' he read. His voice brought the words of the ancient prophet to life.

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"Finally he finished the passage and rolled up the scroll. Returning it to the attendant, he sat down. Every  eye was upon him, and the room was tense with anticipation.

'Today,' he said, 'this scripture is fulfilled in your hearing.'

"That was too much. To the people's way of thinking, it bordered on blasphemy. Angrily they asked each other, 'Isn't this the carpenter? Isn't this Mary's son and the brother of James, Joseph, Jude, and Simon? Aren't his sisters here with us?"

"Seizing him, they dragged him out of the synagogue and to the brow of the hill on which the town was built. They had every intention of hurling him off the cliff to his death, but he walked right through the crowd and no man laid a hand on him. ' It was the most uncanny thing I've ever seen.

Still, my relief was short-lived. Seeing their anger, I knew it was only a matter of time until they killed him."
Pressing my lips together, I close my eyes. A tear escapes from the corner of my eye
leaving wet tracks down my cheek. Quickly I wipe it away and force myself to give Salome a brave smile. She returns my smile and her eyes tell me she understands.
"That's the last time Jesus came home. From that day he lived in Capernaum. He lived there, I believe, to spare me. He knew how I suffered when people attacked him, especially the religious leaders.

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"But we cannot escape our destiny, and the sword of which Simeon spoke is mine. It will only be a matter of time until it pierces my soul to the hilt."

We sit for sometime in silence, each of us immersed in our own thoughts. I sense that Salome would like to comfort me, but she is too wise to give me false assurances. And like me, she is aware of the grave danger Jesus is in.
Together we watch as the sun rises, slowly washing the darkness from the city below. Suddenly our solitude is interrupted by a frantic pounding at the door.
It is John, Salome's youngest son, and he brings the worst possible news. Jesus has been arrested and is being taken to Pilate, the Roman governor. Frantically we fling on our clothes and follow John through the winding streets toward the governor's palace.
By the time we arrive, a crowd has gathered and their mood is ugly. Working our way through the mass of people, we manage to position ourselves near the front.
We are standing directly under the governor's balcony when he leads Jesus out. At the sight of him I nearly faint.
"What have they done to him?" I cry, unable to tear my eyes from his mutilated face. His lips are a bloody pulp, one eye, is swollen completely shut, and his back is ripped to raw shreds-the work of a Roman whip. On his head, thrust far down, is a cruel crown of three-inch Judeaen thorns. A discarded robe of royal purple is carelessly thrown about his shoulders, making the mockery complete.
Motioning for the crowd to be silent, Pilate says, "Here is your king."
At that the mob goes mad. "Crucify him!" they scream, “Crucify him!”
"Shall I crucify your king?" he asks.
As with one voice they shout, "We have no king but Caesar."

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Seeing he cannot prevail, Pilate yields to their will and orders Jesus put to death. We watch in stunned disbelief as the soldiers lead him away.

Numbly we follow them up the Via Dolorosa, and out the city gates to a skull-shaped hill called Golgotha. There they crucify him. They strip him and nail him to a cross. As the executioner swings his heavy hammer, I turn away in revulsion, burying my face in John's chest while spasms of grief rack my tortured soul.

John covers my head with his arms, but there is no way to shut out the madness. Shouted orders from the soldiers mingle with the tortured screams of the condemned, and are joined in the fearful din by the grief-stricken wails of family and friends.

Worst of all are the taunts of the religious leaders. "He saved others," they sneer. "Let him save himself if he is the Christ of God, the Chosen One."

Others mock him saying, "You who are going to destroy the temple and build it in three days, come down from the cross and save yourself!...Let this Christ, this King of Israel, come down now from the cross, that we may see and believe."

Such cruelty, such hatred, I have never seen. It is as if hell itself has erupted and is spewing its poisonous venom over the earth. Then, in the midst of that cesspool of hatred, I hear the sound of love!

"Father," His voice is raspy, hardly recognizable at all. "Father, forgive them, for they do not know what they are doing."

His words are no more than a ragged whisper, but there is no mistaking them. To my knowledge, no one but Jesus dares call God "Father."

Like a magnet his voice draws me. Turning my face from John's chest I look full at my firstborn son. When I do, the sword of which Simeon spoke pierces my soul anew. My grief and sorrow are unbearable, yet there is something else too. A

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wordless hope, an inner conviction too intangible to be defined, yet too real to be denied.

Somehow I know that he is not a helpless captive, but a willing sacrifice. In a way I cannot explain, I truly understand that his execution is not simply a miscarriage of human justice, but the just decree of a holy God. For this reason was he born.

He is the Lamb of God, doing what he came to do, suffering for the sins of the world.

Caiaphas, Pilate, the Roman soldiers, even the bloodthirsty mob, are not his executioners. They are mere instruments in the hand of God. This crucifixion is God's doing-a terrible but vital part of His eternal plan.

Knowing this does not make my grief any less, but it does give me the strength to bear it. Now I want to encourage Jesus.

I want to let him know I understand what he is doing, that I support him.

Breaking away from John, I run to the foot of the cross where he can see me.

Looking down, his gaze finds me, and for a moment we hold each other with our eyes. I feel John put his arm around me, but I cannot tear my eyes away from Jesus.

"Dear woman," he says, and there is so much love, so much compassion in his words, I think my heart will break. How can he think of me at a time like this, I ask myself

Then his eyes shift to John, and he says, "Here is your son." And to John he says, "Here is your mother."

Something must have passed between them then, some unspoken message perhaps, because John takes my arm and leads me away. I don't want to go; I can't bear to leave Jesus to die alone. Yet I know I can't stay. Jesus wants me to go. He wants

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to spare me the pain of watching him die, and I cannot deny him this final act of kindness.

The sky is growing dark as I descend from Golgotha and turn toward Jerusalem. John lets me lean on him as he leads me toward the home of my sister. A good thing too, for I am nearly blind with grief. Now that Simeon's sword has finally been revealed I find it is much worse than I could ever have imagined.

Still, I draw some small comfort from the knowledge that this is part of God's eternal plan. Turning to John I say, "In birth, Jesus became my son and I his mother. In death, he becomes my savior and, unworthy sinner though I am, I can now become a child of God. Through him I too can call God 'Father.'"

## SOURCE INFORMATION

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